

Where the Nazis Killed

A Question-and-Answer Examination of the
“Not on Home Soil” Thesis

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Abstract

This paper examines whether the Nazi regime deliberately sited its industrial murder operations outside the German heartland. The thesis is tested against killing statistics for each major site type: the six dedicated extermination camps, the mass-shooting programme in the occupied East, the concentration camps inside Germany and Austria, and the deportation routes of Jews from Germany and Western Europe. The evidence strongly supports the core claim for systematic genocide: every extermination camp stood east of the 1937 German border, and the “Holocaust by bullets” was almost entirely confined to occupied Soviet and Baltic territory. Two important refinements emerge. First, Auschwitz and Chelmno were in territory legally annexed to the Reich, though treated as a colonial periphery. Second, substantial killing did occur inside Germany and Austria through the euthanasia programme, the concentration-camp system, and the 1944–45 death marches—but it was organized differently: framed as medicine, punishment, or military necessity, not as the immediate total extermination of whole populations. The sharpest version of the thesis is that industrial annihilation of entire communities was placed beyond the German public gaze, a pattern corroborated by the T4 experience of 1940–41, Himmler’s Posen speeches, and the telling fact that German and Western Jews were transported hundreds of kilometres eastward to be murdered rather than killed near home.

version: 2026-09-23-18:02:22-CEST-d415a9bf-main

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1 The Thesis and the Evidence

Q1 What is the “not on home soil” thesis?

The thesis holds that Nazi Germany deliberately *placed* its industrial murder operations—extermination camps, mass shooting actions, and mobile killing units—in the occupied Eastern territories (principally Poland, Ukraine, Belarus, and the Baltic states) rather than within Germany and Austria themselves. The implied mechanism is that the regime was constrained by German public opinion and the practicalities of social control at home, and that it exploited the lawlessness of occupied territory to carry out killings it could not easily conceal or justify domestically.

Short verdict. The numbers strongly support the thesis for the *systematic genocide*: every extermination camp, and nearly every mass-shooting site, lay east of the 1937 German border, and the victims were overwhelmingly killed there. Two refinements matter, however. (a) Some of the largest sites—Auschwitz and Chelmno—were in territory the Nazis had formally annexed into the Reich. (b) Large-scale killing *did* happen inside Germany and Austria: the euthanasia programme, the concentration camps, Soviet POW camps, and the 1945 death marches. It was organized differently. The sharper version of the thesis is therefore: *industrial murder of whole populations was placed outside the German core and away from German public view, while killing inside Germany was framed as medicine, punishment, labour, or war.*

Figures throughout this paper are the ranges common in standard scholarship [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2024a, Hilberg, 2003, Snyder, 2010]. Many are contested within their ranges; the sources cited for each site give the current scholarly consensus.

2 The Extermination Camps

Q2 Where were the six dedicated extermination camps, and how many people did each kill?

Six installations were built specifically to murder people on arrival. Together they account for roughly 2.7–3.0 million deaths. Every one was located in pre-war Polish territory—though the Nazis’ own administrative designations differed, as the table shows.

Table 1: The six dedicated extermination camps, their location under Nazi rule, and scholarly death-toll estimates. Sources: USHMM Holocaust Encyclopedia entries for each camp [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2024a,o,c,m,e,h]; Arad [1987] for the Reinhard camps.

Camp	Location today	Nazi admin. status	Killed (approx.)
Auschwitz–Birkenau	Poland (S. Silesia)	<i>Annexed to the Reich</i> : Province of Upper Silesia	~1.1 million total; ~1 million Jews
Treblinka	Poland (Masovia)	General Government (occupied)	~925,000 Jews
Bełżec	Poland (Galicia)	General Government	~434,500 Jews
Sobibór	Poland (Lublin district)	General Government	≥167,000
Chełmno	Poland (Warthegau)	<i>Annexed to the Reich</i> : Reichsgau Wartheland	≥156,300 (incl. ~152,000 Jews and ~4,300 Roma)
Majdanek	Poland (Lublin)	General Government (also served as concentration camp)	95,000–130,000 system-wide; 89,000–110,000 Jews

Q2a Why do Auschwitz and Chełmno complicate the thesis?

Both were in territories the Nazis had *formally annexed* into the Reich, not merely occupied. On a strict reading, they were therefore “on home soil.” Two responses are important.

- The Nazis conceived the annexed eastern territories as *colonial* land to be “Germanized”: Polish populations were expelled or enslaved, and there was no established German civil society to observe, protest, or be disturbed by what went on there. The “public view” that the regime feared was German public view, not a juridical line on a map.
- Even within the General Government (occupied but not annexed), the absence of a German civilian population was the operative condition. The regime drew the line at the German *heartland* and its people, not at the 1937 border.

3 The Holocaust by Bullets

Q3 What was the “Holocaust by bullets,” and where did it happen?

Alongside the gas-chamber programme, *Einsatzgruppen* (mobile killing squads) and other German and collaborating units shot Jews—and others—in mass outdoor executions throughout the occupied Soviet Union, Ukraine, Belarus, and the Baltic states. Up to two million Jews died this way; they represent roughly one-third of all Holocaust victims [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2024i].

Every major site listed below was in occupied Soviet or Baltic territory—none in Germany or Austria. Yahad-In Unum has since documented thousands of smaller shooting pits across the same region through field investigation and witness testimony [Yahad-In Unum, 2024].

Table 2: Major mass-shooting sites. Sources: United States Holocaust Memorial Museum [2024i,b,l]; Snyder [2010].

Site	Country today	Date(s)	Killed (approx.)
Babi Yar (Babyn Yar), Kyiv	Ukraine	Sept. 1941–1943	33,771 Jews in initial two-day massacre; ~100,000 total (Jews, Roma, POWs, others)
Ponary (Paneriai) forest, Vilnius	Lithuania	1941–1944	~70,000–75,000, mainly Jews
Rumbula forest, Riga	Latvia	30 Nov. 8–9 Dec. 1941	≥25,000 Jews from Riga ghetto
Ninth Fort, Kaunas	Lithuania	1941–1943	~50,000 total incl. ~9,200 on 29 Oct. 1941
Maly Trostenets, Minsk	Belarus	1942–1944	~40,000–60,000 (scholarly range; Soviet-era claims of 200,000+)

Table 2 continued

Site	Country today	Date(s)	Killed (approx.)
Kamianets-Podilskyi	Ukraine	26–28 Aug. 1941	~23,600 in three days, incl. deported Hungarian Jews
Drobitsky Yar, Kharkiv	Ukraine	Dec. 1941–1943	~15,000–20,000
Bogdanovka / Domanevka, Transnistria	Ukraine	Dec. 1941–Mar. 1942	~40,000–50,000+ (mainly Romanian and local forces)
Odessa massacre	Ukraine	Oct. 1941	~25,000–34,000 (Romanian forces)

4 Killing Inside Germany and Austria

Q4 Did large-scale killing occur inside Germany and Austria? What form did it take?

Yes—and this is the most important counter-evidence for a naïve version of the thesis. Substantial killing occurred on Reich soil, but it was structured very differently from the exterminationist operations in the East.

Table 3: Categories of killing inside Germany and Austria. Sources: United States Holocaust Memorial Museum [2024n,j,d,f]; Wachsmann [2015].

Category	Killed (approx.)	Notes
T4 centralized gassings (1940–41)	70,273	Six centres: Grafeneck, Brandenburg, Hartheim (Austria), Sonnenstein, Bernburg, Hadamar.
“Wild” euthanasia (1941–45)	~100,000+ inside Reich	Mostly German psychiatric patients. Starvation and lethal medication in institutions; totals across all phases of the programme reach ~250,000 [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2024n].
Aktion 14f13	~15,000–20,000	Sick concentration-camp prisoners gassed at T4 centres.

Table 3 continued

Category	Killed (approx.)	Notes
Mauthausen–Gusen (Austria)	≥95,000	Deadliest camp complex on pre-1938 Reich soil; had a gas chamber. [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2024j]
Buchenwald	≥56,000	Includes ~10,000–13,000 Soviet POWs shot in 1941. [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2024d]
Bergen-Belsen	~70,000 total	~50,000 prisoners died (most in 1945); ~20,000 Soviet POWs died earlier.
Sachsenhausen	~40,000–50,000	Includes Soviet POWs shot via neck-shot facility in autumn 1941.
Neuengamme / Dachau / Flossenbürg / Ravensbrück / Mittelbau-Dora	~43k / 41k / 30k / 30k+ / 20k	Ravensbrück operated a gas chamber in 1945; Dachau had a gas chamber that was used to a limited extent.
Soviet POWs in Stalags in Germany	hundreds of thousands	E.g. Stalag 326 Senne, Zeithain. Most of the ~3.3 million Soviet POW deaths overall occurred in the East, however.
Death marches (1944–45)	~200,000– 350,000	Many deaths occurred on German roads, in full public view [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2024f].

Q4a What is the significance of the T4 euthanasia programme?

T4 is both the strongest counter-evidence and the strongest evidence for the thesis's mechanism.

1. **Counter-evidence.** The first Nazi gas chambers were German, killing Germans, inside Germany. The T4 programme trained the personnel and developed the operational methods later used at Bełżec, Sobibór, and Treblinka [Browning, 2004].
2. **Confirming the mechanism.** T4 also shows *why* the regime moved the killing east. Inside Germany, secrecy leaked: relatives noticed, rumours spread, and Bishop Clemens August Graf von Galen preached publicly against the murders in August 1941. Hitler *officially halted* the centralized gassings on 24 August 1941. Within months, the fully industrial genocide of Jews—designed from the outset for total concealment—was being built

in occupied Poland, where no such constraint existed. The geographic shift followed directly from the failure of domestic concealment.

The concentration camps inside the Reich caused mass death through starvation, labour, disease, and execution. But they did not function as places of *immediate, total extermination on arrival* until the chaos of 1945. That specific function was reserved for the East.

5 The Deportation Routes of German and Western Jews

Q5 Where were Jews from Germany and Western Europe actually murdered?

This may be the cleanest test. If the regime were indifferent to geography, it would have killed Jews where they lived. Instead, almost all were transported hundreds or thousands of kilometres eastward before being murdered.

Table 4: Jewish deportations from Germany and Western Europe. Sources: United States Holocaust Memorial Museum [2024g,k]; Hilberg [2003], Friedländer [2007].

Country of origin	Jews killed	Destination(s)
Germany	160,000–180,000	Deported to Łódź, Riga, Kaunas, Minsk/Maly Trostenets, the Lublin district, and Auschwitz. ~5,000 German Jews shot at the Ninth Fort (Nov. 1941); ~1,000 Berlin Jews shot at Rumbula [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2024g].
Netherlands	~102,000	Almost entirely Auschwitz and Sobibór; only ~5,200 deportees survived [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2024k].
France	~75,000	Mainly Auschwitz.
Belgium	~25,000	Mainly Auschwitz.
Greece	~60,000	Mainly Auschwitz (Thessaloniki Jews, 1943).
Italy	~7,500	Mainly Auschwitz; some to other camps.
Hungary	~430,000	Deported in a concentrated 56-day operation in 1944; almost entirely to Auschwitz-Birkenau, where the gas chambers were running at maximum capacity.

Theresienstadt (in the Protectorate of Bohemia and Moravia, Czech lands) was a *transit ghetto*, not a killing centre. About 33,000 died there from conditions; approximately 88,000 were transported onward to be murdered in the East [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2024g].

Notable exceptions in occupied non-Eastern territory. In Serbia, the Wehrmacht shot Jewish men in 1941, and about 6,300–7,000 women and children were killed in a gas van at Sajmište in Belgrade in 1942. Jasenovac in Croatia (~80,000–100,000 dead) was run by the Ustaša, not the Germans. Natzweiler in Alsace (annexed) had a small gas chamber used for a limited number of victims.

6 Assessment

Q6 What does the evidence show overall? A scorecard.

The table below tests each version of the thesis against the evidence surveyed in the preceding sections.

Claim	Verdict
All six extermination camps were outside pre-1938 Germany and Austria	Yes, fully. Every camp was in pre-war Polish territory.
Mass shootings took place overwhelmingly in occupied Eastern territory	Yes, almost entirely. All major sites were in occupied Soviet or Baltic territory.
No significant killing occurred inside Germany	No. Euthanasia, concentration camps, Soviet POWs, and death marches all killed large numbers inside the Reich.
The killing sites were outside the Reich's legal borders	Partly. Auschwitz and Chełmno were in formally annexed territory, though treated as a colonial periphery.
German Jews themselves were deported east to be murdered	Yes—this is strong evidence. 160,000–180,000 German Jews were killed, overwhelmingly in the East after deportation, not at home.
Industrial murder of whole populations on arrival was placed outside German public view	Yes, strongly supported. This sharper version of the thesis is corroborated by T4 history, the Posen speeches, and the deportation routes of Western Jews.

7 Competing and Complementary Explanations

Q7 What other explanations account for the geographic pattern?

A rigorous examination must weigh five explanations, because the siting of the killing operations has more than one cause.

1. **Demography.** About 3.3 million Jews lived in Poland in 1939 and roughly 5 million in the Soviet sphere, compared with ~500,000 in Germany in 1933 (many of whom had emigrated by 1939). The killing went to where the victims were. This alone predicts most of the geographic pattern, independent of any concern about German sensibilities [Hilberg, 2003, Snyder, 2010].
2. **Logistics.** Dense rail networks, the proximity of existing ghettos, and the availability of large labour pools all favoured sites in occupied Poland.
3. **Secrecy and public sensitivity.** The T4 experience (Section 4a), Himmler's Posen speeches of October 1943—which explicitly treat the

murder of the Jews as a secret “never to be written, never to be spoken”—and the consistent use of “resettlement” euphemisms all point to deliberate concealment from the German public [Friedländer, 2007]. This is the thesis’s strongest positive support.

4. **Ideology and colonial status.** The East was conceived under *Generalplan Ost* as lawless *Lebensraum* to be depopulated and colonized. Different normative frameworks applied there *by design*, not merely out of embarrassment [Browning, 2004].
5. **The *judenrein* goal.** The expulsion of Jews from the Reich was itself a stated aim of Nazi policy from 1933 onward. Deportation eastward was the regime’s preferred instrument even before killing was decided, so the infrastructure and habit of forced movement was already in place when extermination began.

The distinguishing test. Explanation 1 (demography) predicts killing where victims happen to live. The thesis (explanation 3) predicts that location was *chosen* even when victims were not there. The clearest evidence is precisely the Jews of Germany and Western Europe: they were transported hundreds or thousands of kilometres east to be killed. Demography alone cannot explain a Berlin Jew being shot at Rumbula or a Dutch family gassed at Sobibór. The geographic separation of the killing from the victims’ homes is strong evidence that location was a deliberate choice, not a logistical coincidence.

8 Map of Major Killing Sites

Figure 1 shows the approximate locations of the sites discussed in this paper. All six extermination camps cluster in what was pre-war Poland. The mass-shooting sites spread across occupied Ukraine, Belarus, and the Baltic states. The concentration camps and euthanasia centres are visible in Germany and Austria to the west.

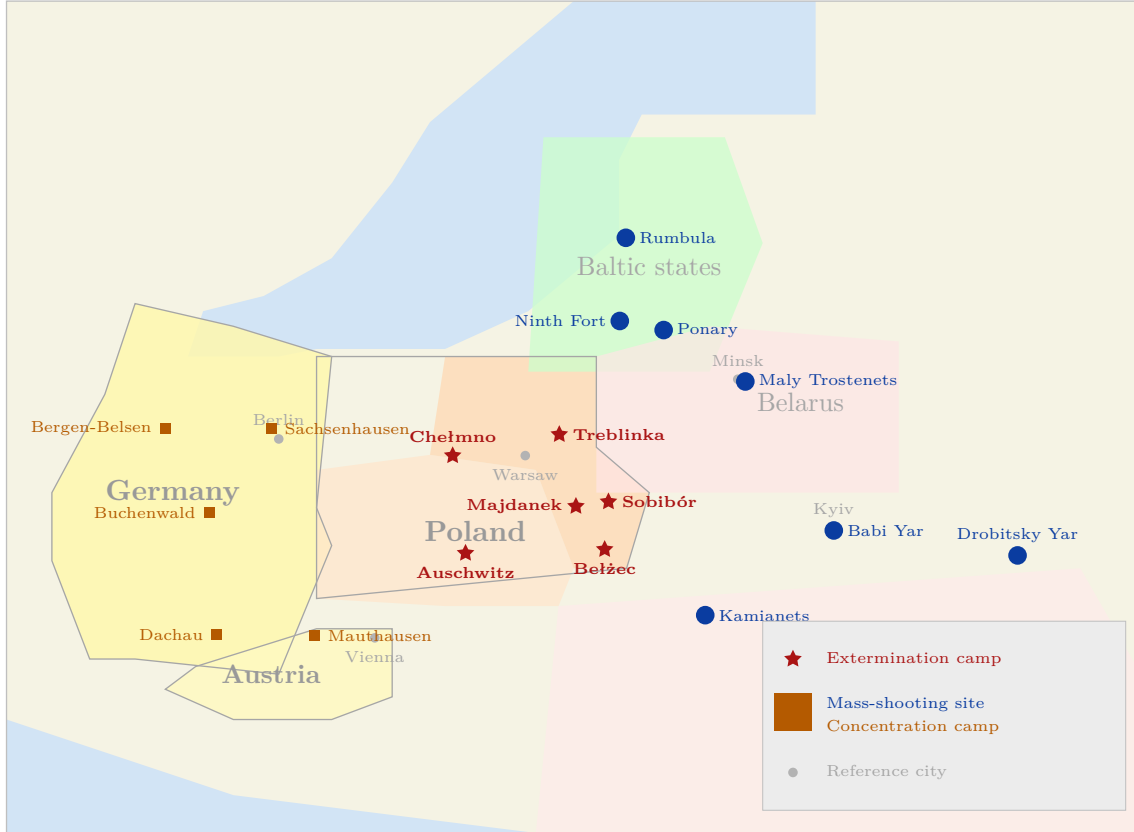


Figure 1: Approximate locations of major Nazi killing sites. Red stars: dedicated extermination camps—all in pre-war Polish territory. Blue circles: major mass-shooting sites—all in occupied Soviet or Baltic territory. Orange squares: concentration camps inside Germany and Austria. Background colours: gold = Germany (1937 borders); pale gold = Austria; amber = occupied/annexed Poland; green = Baltic states; rose = Belarus; salmon = Ukraine. **Note on cartographic accuracy:** this map was generated by an AI-assisted drafting process and should be treated as a thematic sketch, not a geographic reference. The Baltic Sea coastline in particular is approximate; the sea’s southern shore (German, Polish, and Baltic-state coasts) and the Swedish east coast are shown in simplified form, and Scandinavia is cut off by the map’s northern edge.

About This Document

This document represents an exploration created through a collaborative process between a human reader and an AI system.

1. **Question.** The inquiry originated with the question of whether the Nazis systematically avoided placing mass-murder installations on German home soil, and whether numerical evidence supports that thesis.
2. **Initial analysis.** An AI system (Claude, Anthropic) provided a structured survey of killing sites, administrative categories, and death-toll ranges, drawing on standard scholarship (Hilberg, Snyder, USHMM).
3. **Synthesis.** The Q&A format was chosen to make the analytical structure explicit: each question is answered against the evidence, and competing explanations are given equal space.
4. **Verification.** All USHMM encyclopedia URLs were tested for accessibility with automated tools. Books are cited with ISBN numbers as standard scholarly references requiring no URL verification.
5. **Map.** The schematic map was generated using TikZ with coordinates derived from standard latitude/longitude data. It is intentionally schematic and should not be used for precise geographic reference.

The intended audience is a general reader who wants a factually grounded, clearly sourced account of where Nazi mass murder took place and why that geography matters.

Note on References and Verification

This document was produced with AI assistance. All references have been subject to verification.

Verification process:

- All USHMM Holocaust Encyclopedia URLs were tested for accessibility using automated fetch tools. Only articles that returned HTTP 200 with readable content were cited.
- Books are cited as “standard scholarly references” (widely known academic works with ISBN numbers) and do not require URL verification.
- The Yahad-In Unum URL was verified via automated fetch (redirects from yahadinunum.org to yiu.ngo).
- Death-toll figures quoted in the text match the ranges reported on the verified USHMM pages; where ranges differ between sources, the text reflects the range explicitly.
- No generic domain URLs (e.g. reuters.com, theguardian.com) are used.

Verification status by reference type:

- “Verified: URL accessible” — USHMM encyclopedia articles.
- “Standard scholarly reference” — Academic books with ISBN.
- “Verified: URL accessible (canonical redirect)” — Yahad-In Unum.

Important notice. Readers using this document for critical or academic purposes should independently consult the primary sources listed in the bibliography.

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